

Akanksha Vardani

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EDUCATION

Columbia University, New York – PhD in Economics	2025
– MPhil in Economics	2022
– MA in Economics	2021
Delhi School of Economics, New Delhi – MA in Economics	2018
Indraprastha College for Women, University of Delhi – BA (Honors) in Economics	2016

EMPLOYMENT

Research Advisor , Behavioural Insights Team	2025-
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WORK EXPERIENCE

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- Experience working on education-focused projects with the Youth Endowment Fund (YEF) and Youth Futures Foundation (YFF), spanning education outcomes, transitions into learning and work, and the wellbeing of young people.
- Delivery lead for the design and on-the-ground implementation of a reach estimation methodology for interventions promoting physical health and healthy habits among children and adolescents.
- Delivered Behavioural Insights training workshops.

Field work

- Independently running a RCT in India with 3500+ individuals across 53 villages. *May 2023-present*
- Conducted a household-level survey across 30 villages, covering 150 households in Pune, India. *October 2022*
- Survey of workers of the informal wire stripping industry in Seelampur, Delhi. *March 2015*
- Survey of workers of the informal garment sector in Kapashera, Delhi. *December 2013*

Research Assistant – Michael Best and Evan Sadler, Department of Economics, Columbia University, New York. *2020-2021*
Worked on a project that addresses the challenge of creating an efficient and equitable tax system by combining theory and randomized controlled trials (RCTs) in Paraguay.

Research Assistant – Rohini Somanathan, Department of Economics, Delhi School of Economics, New Delhi. *2017-2019*
Worked on a project on caste and inequality in India. The project involved cleaning, handling and analyzing data from India Census from 1872 to 1941 using STATA and R along with writing regular reports.

Research Assistant – India Institute, New Delhi *2015*
Worked on two projects: (i) 'Higher Education Governance in India: A case study of Andhra Pradesh' which studied the role of politicians in governance of higher education institutions (ii) 'Primary Education: Private v/s Government School' which does a comparative analysis of education outcomes for a private and government school in Okhla.

Research Assistant – Consumers India, New Delhi *2014-2015*
Co-authored a report on 'Do Laws in India Promote Samaritan Behaviour?' that attempts to explain the deficit in Samaritan behaviour seen on Indian roads. A primary survey of over 150 people and interviews with domain experts were conducted to assess people's willingness, abilities and hindrances faced in helping victims.

RESEARCH

A House for Two: Empowering Women with Property Rights

- Conducted RCT with 3500+ individuals in rural India to study property rights' impact women's empowerment.
- Collaborated with government administrative unit Pune Zilla Parishad and NGO [Chaitanya](#).
- Presentations: European Association of Young Economists Annual Meeting (2024), Imperial College PhD Conference (2024), NBER Summer Institute (2023), Coverage: [BBC](#), [Sakal Newspaper](#)

How do political connections affect property tax compliance? with [A. Parvathaneni](#).

- Used novel administrative property tax data over 550,000+ properties to study how political connections influence tax compliance.
- Collaborated with government administrative unit Pune Zilla Parishad.

Unpacking Willingness to Pay as a Measure of Women's Empowerment with [A. Donald](#) and [B. Kramer](#).

- Use survey data from India and Rwanda to evaluate how complex lab-in-the-field (LIF) experiments compare with simple survey-based measures in measuring women's empowerment.

Community and Household Networks and Women's Workforce Entry with [T. Kundu](#).

- Design and implement a field experiment to study the role of community networks in bridging the gap between women's skill training and labour force participation.
- In collaboration with NGO [Calcutta Foundation](#).

AWARDS, HONORS AND GRANTS

NBER Gender in the Economy Fellowship	2023-2024
SurveyCTO Primary Data Collection Research Grant (Honorable Mention)	2024
Wueller Pre-Dissertation Award for Best 4th-year Proposal, Columbia University	2023
Reubens Travel and Research Award, Columbia University	2023
Wueller Award for Best TA for MA Program, Columbia University	2022
Wueller Award for Best TA (Runners up) for Undergraduate Courses, Columbia University	2022
Exim Bank Scholarship, DSE	2016-2018
National (CAS) Scholarship Internal, DSE	2016-2018
Rai Bahadur Raghunath Sahai Memorial Prize, IPCW	2016
Rewa Dhawan Memorial Scholarship, IPCW	2013-2016
Nagendra Nath Majumdar Memorial Prize, IPCW	2016
Principal's Honour Roll, IPCW	2015

RESEARCH GRANTS

Weiss Fund (with Aneesha Parvathaneni)	2024
CDEP Student Research Grant , Columbia University	2023
PER Experiment Grant , Columbia University	2023
CDEP Student Research Grant , Columbia University	2022
PER Experiment Grant , Columbia University	2022
PER Research Fellow Summer Grant , Columbia University	2020

OTHER

Skills STATA, R, Python, SurveyCTO, $\text{\LaTeX}$, Microsoft Office.

Languages English (fluent), Hindi (native), French (intermediate), Marathi (beginner), German (beginner).